



CULTURAL MOSAIC: Indian Muslims have peacefully co-existed with others

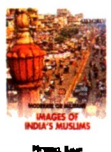
communication and encounters in daily life, as a result of the need to transcend religious boundaries to experience spiritual bliss and enlightenment.

Hasan believes communalism is a modern phenomenon, and there is no instance of its existence in the pre-colonial period. Religious identities turned hostile only in the colonial period. Hasan finds the Marxist way of looking at communal conflicts as forms of class conflict simplistic, and argues that in communal conflicts, issues of identity, culture and power are just as significant. While nationalist historians emphasised the role of British policies in the development of communalism, communal political parties such as the Muslim League and the Hindu Mahasabha played an equally important role. The nature of politics was another important factor. In this context, Hasan discusses the arguments of Francis Robinson, who sees communalism as an inter-elite conflict for a greater share in state resources, and Paul Brass, who considers it a form of mobilisation through which politicians cultivate their constituencies. Both, says Hasan, ignore the agency of the people. There is a need to examine the role of social institutions as well. This leads Hasan to a thorough scrutiny of Muslim educational institutions.

According to Hasan, traditional centres of Muslim education, such as the Darul Ulum in Deoband and Firangi Mahal in Lucknow did not preach religious animosity, but in cultivating an exclusive identity based on Islam, they strengthened communal identities and prevented the integration of Indian Muslims into the national mainstream. He discusses the research of Barbara Metcalf, who has studied Darul Ulum with great sensitivity, and Robinson's work on the Firangi Mahal, which showed that the *ulemas* in Lucknow are nationalistic scholars, but maintains that the centres reduced the inter-communal spaces in the social life of Indian Muslims, and, in their insistence on *shari'a*, buttressed communalism. Hasan writes with verve and passion, arguing in favour of secularism and tolerance. At a time when many of us are losing faith in co-existence and peace, the book revives our hopes once again. ■

KEEPING THE FAITH

Another book on Muslims of India shows them as having a distinctive identity due to centuries of peaceful inter-religious interaction



MODERATE OR MILITANT: IMAGES OF INDIA'S MUSLIMS

by MUSHIRUL HASAN
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■ By Farhat Hasan

Mushirul Hasan has always defended the composite and tolerant culture of India, and *Moderate and Militant Images of India's Muslims* is another effort in the same direction. One of his central arguments is that Muslims should not be seen as a transnational, insular or homogeneous community defined by the Holy Book and shared rituals. Hasan says Indian Muslims have developed their distinctive identity through living with other religious communities in a spirit of mutual co-existence. The book is centred around three themes: perceptions of 'lived Islam' in the media and among intellectuals in India, the entanglement of 'lived Islam' in India with its composite culture, and inter-religious tolerance. Hasan notes two trends, emerging from differences in the understanding

of religion in social life—one in which Muslims are conceived as an integral part of India, and the other, which considers them to be hostile foreigners.

While writers like V.S. Naipaul might dub the medieval period as a period of Muslim invasions, conversions and destruction, forced conversions were rare, and while an individual ruler might have destroyed a temple, medieval rulers provided generous patronage to temples and pilgrimage sites. In reply to Arun Shourie's belief that people were prohibited from studying Hindu philosophy in the medieval period, Hasan asks him to read the works of Amir Khusrau, Abul Fazl and "other poets and writers who wrote paeans to Hindu gods or translated Sanskrit texts into Persian".

While colonialism might have led to the strengthening of religious identity, it was never the defining identity. Hasan discusses the research of several historians, including M. Mujeeb, Richard Eaton and Asim Roy, as well as the work of poets and visionaries like Rabindranath Tagore, Jawaharlal Nehru and Mirza Ghalib, all of which point to centuries of inter-religious